

1681–1720

MANTUAS AND PETTICOATS

From the 1680s the mantua became the chief item of women's dress, with a linen smock or shift remaining as the main undergarment. A full-length, coat-like garment with elbow-length sleeves, the mantua was worn over the stiffened bodice and skirt of earlier periods. Closed from neck to waist, the sides and back were folded up and secured at the waistline to reveal the skirt below. To fit beneath the mantua, the bodice had straps instead of sleeves and was formed like a corset. It opened down the centre back with a lace fastening and was still long and stiffened and cut low on the chest. The petticoat was full and gathered in at the waistline. By the 1690s the top part of the mantua was worn open to show the bodice. It was filled in with a decorative panel known as a stomacher, which was pinned on to the stiffened bodice beneath.

1684

Curled hair
worn looseRolled full
sleeves of
linen smock

Silk nightgown During the Restoration famous beauties were painted in languid poses wearing rich silk casual robes (called nightgowns) over a linen smock. This red silk garment, worn by Charles II's mistress, has decorative fringing and metal clasps.

Long scarf
covers headLong,
pointed
bodiceCone-shaped
bodice narrows
to waistRuby clasps fix
cloak to mantuaMantua drawn
back over hipsErmine-trim
cloakTextured
silk

1697

Gathered
petticoat

1709

Riding hood Long scarves were often worn to cover the head outdoors, and riding hoods (hooded cloaks) were also popular. The long, cloak-like fabric shown here may have been used more for effect in a portrait than as a practical wearable garment.

Bejewelled mantua This silver-grey silk mantua, worn by the Duchess of Burgundy, is embellished with rubies and other jewels. Over this she wears an ermine-trimmed cloak of blue and gold brocade, fixed at her shoulders with jewelled clasps.

Gold fringe
trim